

S02-01 - The Fallout Investigation

Player text

With the creature dealt with, the wreck is yours to read. Up close, the story stops adding up. The cart was stripped clean before anything wild got to it. The driver's wounds are not all bites. And worked into one carriage wheel, where it has no business being, is a snarl of black thorn that does not match this stretch of road.

Public objective

Work out what really happened here before you move on.

Raw source

- Id: S02-01
- Type: scene
- Sectionid: ACT-TWO
- Sectiontitle: Act Two: Cargo Reclaimers
- Title: The Fallout Investigation
- Shorttitle: Fallout Investigation
- Order: 301
- Playersafe: True
- Completioneligible: True
- Image: assets/scenes/S02-01-the-fallout-investigation.png
- Alt: The Fallout Investigation scene art for Cargo Reclaimers.
- Caption: The cart scene becomes evidence of a claim war, not a random wilderness hazard.
- Mood: Cargo Reclaimers
- Gmgoal: Let the party confirm the wreck was staged, find the planted bramble, and realize the ambush is closing in.
- Publicobjective: Work out what really happened here before you move on.
- Readaloud: With the creature dealt with, the wreck is yours to read. Up close, the story stops adding up. The cart was stripped clean before anything wild got to it. The driver's wounds are not all bites. And worked into one carriage wheel, where it has no business being, is a snarl of black thorn that does not match this stretch of road.
- Gmnotes: Deepen Act 1's clue instead of replaying it: body, cart, wheel, tracks, then watchers. Player-safe conclusion: people staged this and marked the carriage.
- Gmscript: Say: "The animal part of this scene is over. Now the wreck gets stranger. The cart was stripped before anything fed here, the killing wound is too clean for teeth, and the thorn in your wheel means somebody got close to your carriage. What do you inspect first?" If they ask who did it, say: "You do not have a name. You have method: staged, local, and deliberate."
- Gmreadaloud: The cart was stripped clean before anything wild got to it. The driver's wounds are not all bites. A snarl of black thorn is worked into one carriage wheel, where it has no business being.
- Gmchecklist: If Act 1 already revealed the slit throat, frame this as confirmation

of staging, not a repeat reveal. Offer Group Action Roll: one leader, helpers feed evidence. Start or tick the Closing In countdown if they linger loudly. Do not name the faction yet.

- Gmprivate: The staging points to organized people in the preserve. Do not decide the driver's killer; the README canon flag stays unresolved. The planted bramble is the handoff into S02-02 and the ambush board.
- Playertakeaway: You now know three things: the wreck was staged, the stagers know this forest, and they have already touched your carriage.
- Storytakeaway: The party is the target, not a bystander; the road incident is becoming an ambush.
- Mechanictakeaway: Investigation can be a Group Action Roll: one PC leads with Instinct or Knowledge while others help assemble the scene.
- Rollcards: s02-01-get-the-road-moving-again S02-01 Get the road moving again Get the road moving again Strength Finesse Strength Finesse 12 Strength moves the cart; Finesse fixes the wheel or pin. The Bramble Union watches while the party is exposed. Critical Success: best possible version of the action; gain Hope and clear 1 Stress. Add an extra benefit that follows from the fiction. Success with Hope: the PC gets what they wanted and gains Hope. Keep the position clean or generous. Success with Fear: the PC gets what they wanted, but the GM gains Fear and introduces a cost, complication, or pressure. Failure with Hope: the PC does not get the full result, but gains Hope and receives a useful thread, clue, or safer next option. Failure with Fear: the PC fails and the GM gains Fear. Make a hard move that follows from the fiction. The Bramble Union watches while the party is exposed. Use a hard complication, lost time, worse position, GM Fear, or mark Stress. Apply an official condition only if the fiction and rules justify it. The attempt falls short, but a partial thread appears. Offer one clue, weak position, or safer follow-up. The PC gets the core result, but it costs time, noise...
- Entityids: vendor-cart tamsin-vell bramble-strand torn-shipping-seals route-ledger cracked-pocket-ward tamsins-home-token whitefire-custodian strixwolf-mother barnacle keystone-asset marlowe-fairwind bramble-union damage-armor sealed-keystone-crate hush cat-squirrels fox-bats
- Entities: vendor-cart Vendor Cart item Item / Asset assets/icons/item.png assets/entities/vendor-cart.png Vendor Cart Overturned cart that blocks the road and sets up the ambush mystery. Wrecked cart and investigation hub Overturned cart that blocks the road and sets up the ambush mystery.; use Vendor Cart as a concrete table object with texture, ownership, and a reason it matters now. Give players a tangible handle on Tamsin Vell, Incident Response Placard, Bramble Strand, whether they inspect, carry, return, trade, or refuse it. Overturned cart that blocks the road and sets up the ambush mystery. tamsin-vell Tamsin Vell npc NPC / Ally assets/icons/npc.png assets/npc-images/tamsin-vell/portrait_base.png TAM-zin VEL The dead driver at the overturned cart; evidence suggests humanoid murder, not just animal attack. The human cost at the first crime scene. Tamsin Vell a dead delivery driver at an overturned cart, with evidence that a person killed her ordinary, dutiful, dead before the party can learn the whole person In life, finish one more delivery and get home with enough coin to reduce her debt. Her voice is unavailable; use letters, route notes, and small belongings instead. a dead...
- Itemids: tamsins-home-token cracked-pocket-ward
- Clueids: bramble-strand bramble-claim-marker torn-shipping-seals route-ledger

tamsin-s-wedding-cord old-contract-tags bramble-are-criminals-noticetm

- Statecontrols: slitThroatDiscovered Slit throat already known checkbox If checked, do not re-reveal; confirm staging instead. stagingDiscovered Staging discovered checkbox Mark once players connect cart, wound, bramble, or tracks as deliberate. closingInCountdown Closing In countdown number 4 Tick for loud delay, messy evidence handling, or Fear. Resolve pressure in S02-02.
- Mechanicids: action-roll strength finesse gm-moves help-an-ally tag-team-roll knowledge instinct hope fear countdown
- Playerquestions: What detail in The Fallout Investigation tells you the official story is incomplete? Who notices the human cost first, and how do they show it? What small object, smell, or sound makes this scene feel real?
- Relationshipprompts: Which PC quietly checks on someone else here? Who disagrees about the right thing to do without breaking trust?
- Ownershipprompt: Name one detail in The Fallout Investigation that belongs to your character's point of view.
- Fearsponds: Spend Fear to separate true evidence from a tempting false read, or put the carriage/cargo under time pressure. Close the ambush net or put a PC between cargo and a frightened reclamer. Reveal a personal effect that makes victory emotionally complicated.
- Choicesconsequences: Preserve evidence Clearer read and a stronger parley position. S02-03 Presence difficulty can drop if they cite the staging without accusing blindly. If they rush, they still learn the threat but lose leverage. Track the planted bramble Predicts where watchers likely stood. S02-02 spot check can start with a strong fictional position. If ignored, the ambush begins with less warning. Pocket or disturb effects They gain clues or loot quickly. S02-04 survivors may distrust them if personal effects were treated as trophies. Careful handling keeps later dialogue warmer.
- Lootclues: Torn seal Route ledger Bramble strand Tamsin's Home-Token: A small thumb-polished token on a cord hangs beside the torn blue scarf, warm from wear and etched with a tiny house mark instead of a company seal. Cracked Pocket Ward?: A cheap little ward charm sits cracked down the middle, still trying to glow through a smiling warranty sticker.
- Handoutids: Torn Shipping Seals
- Sourcescenelug: S02-01-the-fallout-investigation
- Sourcefiles: dist/Act2_Upgrade_Packet/ACT2_SCENE_UPGRADES.md
dist/Act2_Upgrade_Packet/ACT2_PER_CHARACTER.md
- References: Previous clue seed #S01-02 Eyes in the Brush #S02-02
- Storyscope: Perceived antagonist: the forest. True antagonist: the corporate lie about the forest. The players never confront it directly. They are meant to feel it by the end. Every act offers at least one guaranteed and one earned hint that the danger is manufactured and the forest is not the enemy. The reclaimers target the cargo and manifest, not purses, and avoid killing when possible. REFLAVOR GUARANTEED Their gear includes salvaged, repainted Grail/Kazrak kit: ex-workers, not feral bandits. REFLAVOR GUARANTEED Knowledge Medium 15 to name the issue "That stone belongs in the ground." "You do not know what you are carrying." ADD EARNED A spared/captured reclamer says monster attacks spiked when protection contracts went on sale. ADD EARNED Presence Medium 15; requires mercy or capture Instinct: spot ambush. Presence: parley/interrogate. Knowledge: recognize corporate-issue gear.

ACT2 Act 2: Bramble ambush 90 0:55 to 1:30 1:30 first combat and possible interrogation Abstract the fight via a Group Action roll; keep one captured reclaimer for the interrogation seed.

- Livetools: scene MAP-S01-02

- Percharacterlayer: garrick-reed Garrick Reed Staged crime scene Recognizes the scene as staged immediately: looted, displayed, and too clean in the wrong places.

Knowledge 12 The blade work was professional, not panicked; the death was made to look like wilderness violence. Can lead the Group Action Roll and turn separate observations into one clean read. Garrick, this is staged and you know staged. Want to run the read while the others feed you details? barnacle Barnacle Staging and salvage Clocks that the cart was professionally stripped; someone knew what was worth taking and moved fast. Instinct 13 The thorn in the wheel was placed, and drag-trails lead toward the likely ambush position. Can back-trace the approach and give the party a better fictional position before S02-02. Barnacle, someone planted that thorn in your wheel on purpose. Want to follow how they got close? varian-soto Varian Soto Scent layers Smells multiple people on the wreck, recently, with nervous sweat under the blood and mud. Instinct 12 Counts roughly four or five distinct people and can tell they were frightened while they worked. Can separate animal scavenging, human staging, and the direction the watchers withdrew...

- Takeawayhelp: Player takeaway You now know three things: the wreck was staged, the stagers know this forest, and they have already touched your carriage. "Staged, local, and close. That thorn in your wheel means this was aimed at you." "You can inspect the body, cart, wheel, tracks, or treeline. The safest next action is to choose one thread and name who watches the carriage while you do it." Keep the next action concrete: body, cart, wheel, tracks, treeline, or carriage guard. The evidence should feel playable, not abstract. help-an-ally tag-team-roll knowledge instinct countdown Story takeaway The party is the target, not a bystander; the road incident is becoming an ambush. "This was not random damage on a road. This was a message and a setup." "The evidence says the people who did it understand the preserve, planned the stop, and got close to your carriage before you noticed." Do not reveal the self-name or motive yet. The story truth for this scene is target, method, and proximity. help-an-ally tag-team-roll knowledge instinct countdown Mechanic takeaway Investigation can be a Group Action Roll: one PC leads with Instinct or Knowledge while others help assemble the scene. "If you want to...

- Playerbeats: S02-01-stripped-clean Stripped clean Stripped clean before scavenging assets/scenes/S02-01-the-fallout-investigation.png The Fallout Investigation scene art for Cargo Reclaimers. The cart was looted before the animal arrived. Whoever did this knew what was worth taking and moved fast. The cart was looted before the animal arrived. Whoever did this knew what was worth taking and moved fast. The cart was looted before the animal arrived. Whoever did this knew what was worth taking and moved fast. text-first S02-01-not-all-bites Not all bites The wound does not match the story assets/scenes/S02-01-the-fallout-investigation.png The Fallout Investigation scene art for Cargo Reclaimers. The feeding is messy, but the killing wound is clean. This death started with a blade, not teeth. The feeding is messy, but the killing wound is clean. This death started with a blade, not teeth. The feeding is messy, but the killing wound is clean. This death started with a blade, not teeth. text-first S02-01-thorn-wheel Thorn in the wheel The carriage was marked assets/scenes/S02-01-the-fallout-investigation.png The Fallout Investigation scene

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- Gmbeats: S02-01-stripped-clean Stripped clean Stripped clean before scavenging Say: "The cart was stripped before the animal ever fed here. Someone knew what mattered and took it quickly." The cart was looted before the animal arrived. Whoever did this knew what was worth taking and moved fast. The wreck shifts from animal aftermath to staged human action. Basic facts are automatic; roll only for reconstruction or hidden detail. The cart is evidence of planning, not chaos. Player takeaway The cart is evidence of planning, not chaos. "The cart was stripped before the animal ever fed here. Someone knew what mattered and took it quickly." "The playable facts are: The cart was looted before the animal arrived. Whoever did this knew what was worth taking and moved fast." Use this beat to point the table at one immediate choice. The player-facing fact is: The cart was looted before the animal arrived. Whoever did this knew what was worth taking and moved fast. knowledge instinct Story takeaway The wreck shifts from animal aftermath to staged human action. "The cart was stripped before the animal ever fed here. Someone knew what mattered and took it quickly." "The story fact you can trust is..."
- Beatautoplayeligible: True
- Beatautoplaydefault: False
- Beatautoplayintervalms: 8000
- Playersafeprojection: S02-01 scene The Fallout Investigation
assets/scenes/S02-01-the-fallout-investigation.png The Fallout Investigation scene
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- Companionmapids: MAP-S01-02
- Slidenumber: 32
- Totalslides: 110
- Spotlights: SPOT-M-DISCOVERY discovery-rolls discovery-rolls M12 S02-01 med mandatory first-use Read the Scene Clue rolls are active behavior. Use Instinct or Knowledge when players inspect what happened. Notice ambush setup: Instinct 14. Sense the package's wrongness later: Instinct 15, with Soar or Crit answering more. Recognize the lion seal: Knowledge 12, automatic for Marlowe. Discovery checks wiki/mechanic/discovery-rolls teach-by-example Make investigation a playable procedure instead of a lore dump. mechanic defer-if-clock-critical True True SPOT-C-BARNACLE-EARLY barnacle Barnacle early S02-01 med optional first-use Barnacle, See What Is Wrong Rogue attention catches staged details. Barnacle, you clock a staging mismatch. Call it out as a concrete observation, not proof. Spotlight: Barnacle wiki/character/barnacle in-scene-prompts Discovery checks wiki/mechanic/discovery-

rolls teach-by-example character defer-if-clock-critical True True
- Spotlightsummary: 1 1

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